

Chapter 156-1

What Liang Shi could be certain of was that she had never left a good impression on Lu Jiayi.

The first time they met was at the entrance of the art museum, where she almost got into a fight with Qin Lishuang.

The second time was at the Qin family banquet. She had failed to save Xu Qingzhu then, and her appearance rushing to find Xu Qingzhu was rather disheveled.

Where exactly had she left a good impression on Lu Jiayi that warranted her praise?

Liang Shi felt it was probably Lu Jiayi saying this to please Xu Qingzhu.

In fact, Xu Qingzhu really was very happy.

She even wanted to invite Lu Jiayi when they went to eat together.

Lu Jiayi was tactful and waved at them. "President Xu, you go eat with your wife. I'll just find somewhere to eat on my own."

"Wishing you a pleasant evening," Lu Jiayi said.

Liang Shi also waved at her and didn't forget to give her recommendations. "The army-style hot pot around the corner is quite good, and so is the Japanese restaurant next door."

Lu Jiayi nodded. "Got it, thank you."

Very polite.

She always wore a proper smile on her face. One could tell at a glance she was a person of great refinement, not some uneducated nouveau riche.

It was precisely because of this that one couldn't bring themselves to dislike her.

And it also made one feel a particular sense of crisis.

At this moment, the moon hung high, and stars were scattered finely across the black night sky like sprinkled diamond fragments.

The streetlights were all lit, enveloping the entire city in a layer of gentle light.

Liang Shi held Xu Qingzhu's hand as they walked along the road. Several times, she caught herself spacing out.

The two chose to eat Hunan cuisine.^1^

When they arrived at the restaurant, Liang Shi sat across from Xu Qingzhu and only then saw her eyes.

The dark circles under her eyes were very heavy—so dark that even foundation couldn't cover them.

Seeing Liang Shi looking over, Xu Qingzhu reached up with both hands to cover her face.
"What?"

Liang Shi reached out to wipe the foundation under her eyes.

Xu Qingzhu leaned back. "We're in public."

Liang Shi asked: "Have you not been sleeping well lately?"

"Yeah." Xu Qingzhu sighed. "I've been busy with a new project lately. It turns out Lu Jiayi is from the Lu family of the capital. I heard my grandfather mention them before. Her grandfather and my grandfather apparently had quite a good relationship, so we're preparing to collaborate."

While speaking, Xu Qingzhu lowered her head to unwrap the chopsticks, avoiding Liang Shi's piercing gaze.

But after being together for so long, how could she not notice these details?

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "So... is Lu Jiayi good?"

"In what way?" Xu Qingzhu handed her the chopsticks, then smiled. "As a business partner, she's indeed impeccable. Her work ability is frighteningly strong. Look at my dark circles..."

Xu Qingzhu said this, then immediately covered her eyes again. "Forget it, you'd better not look. It's too ugly."

"It's all her fault." Xu Qingzhu said: "Even when I was in school, I never experienced this feeling. She's really... such an overachiever."²

"For example?" Liang Shi asked gently.

"A proposal I thought would take two days to finish, she can complete in three hours." Xu Qingzhu said: "Working with her requires particularly high concentration and particularly strong ability to stay up late."

It had been so long since they'd seen each other, and Xu Qingzhu seemed even more animated than before, talking endlessly about work matters.

What she talked about the most was still Lu Jiayi.

The name Lu Jiayi appeared frequently at a rate of once every three minutes.

"She's like someone training an eagle through sleep deprivation."³ Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "She worked my assistant until she got sick."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I thought Teacher Xu was already overachieving enough." Liang Shi laughed lightly. "Didn't expect there'd be someone even more intense than Teacher Xu."

"Then you really should interact with Lu Jiayi sometime." Xu Qingzhu sighed.

One could tell that during these few days of working with Lu Jiayi, Xu Qingzhu was quite happy.

At least collaborating with Lu Jiayi was a pleasant thing.

No one would dislike a partner who was highly efficient and full of passion for work.

This was also why Xu Qingzhu was full of praise for Lu Jiayi.

It's just that hearing these words, Liang Shi felt rather uncomfortable.

Her mood was somewhat low.

There weren't many people in the restaurant, and the server quickly brought out the dishes.

Xu Qingzhu noticed her low spirits and tentatively asked: "Are you unhappy?"

Liang Shi answered instinctively: "Huh? Not really."

Even she herself sounded uncertain.

Xu Qingzhu then became certain. "Is it because I keep bringing up Lu Jiayi?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Silence was the best answer.

The two of them sat across from each other at the table, with steam rising from the hot dishes between them.

Clearly less than a meter apart, yet it felt like the Milky Way separated them.

It gave one a dreamlike, surreal feeling.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, then suddenly smiled lightly: "Jealous?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, then nodded.

She could see the caution beneath Xu Qingzhu's smile, so she picked up some bright red spicy dish for her and said with a smile: "Teacher Xu is so beautiful and has such strong work ability. Of course many people would like you."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu was momentarily stunned. Resting her chin on her hand, she looked intently at Liang Shi: "Does that include you?"

Liang Shi nodded with certainty: "Very much so."

Xu Qingzhu's smile spread from the corners of her eyes, gentle and beautiful.

But Liang Shi saw an unfamiliar smile on her—a smile that was being forced.

It looked calm and composed, yet seemed to be missing something compared to before.

Liang Shi finished the meal absent-mindedly. When they were about to leave the restaurant, she saw Xu Qingzhu lowering her head to rub her eyes, and suddenly understood.

Xu Qingzhu was too exhausted, lacking her previous vitality.

Whether teasing or bantering, she was forcing herself to do it.

It wasn't the same as how she was in front of Lu Jiayi.

In front of Lu Jiayi, she was relaxed, carefree, without lingering affection and without anything to hide.

But in front of Liang Shi, she kept hiding things, afraid Liang Shi would discover her vulnerability, her dishevelment, her discomfort. So it was like she was wearing a mask.

She was walking on a knife's edge, trying to give the impression of being at ease, yet her acting skills weren't quite up to par.

It was probably the torment of the nightmares that came every day, plus the development of new business. She was like a component placed on a gear, spinning at high speed without a moment's rest.

Yet after seeing Liang Shi, she still had to wear a smile, say nice things, and tease and joke like before to liven up the atmosphere.

Because Liang Shi was too reserved.

Liang Shi habitually hid all her words away, hid her true self away.

So Xu Qingzhu had to be the one taking initiative.

But in front of Lu Jiayi, she didn't need to.

Because there was no need to pretend, she could chat and laugh easily. Even when exhausted, her eyes would sparkle when talking about work.

Liang Shi's heart sank to the bottom of the sea in an instant.

There were no scenes for her tomorrow morning, so she could go home tonight.

Footnotes:

1. Hunan cuisine (湘菜): One of the Eight Great Traditions of Chinese cuisine, originating from Hunan Province. It is known for its hot and spicy flavors, often using fresh chili peppers, garlic, and shallots.
2. "Overachiever" (卷): The Chinese term "卷" (juǎn) is internet slang derived from "内卷" (involution), referring to excessive competition and overwork culture. Someone who is "卷" works extremely hard, often to an unhealthy degree, setting high standards that pressure others to do the same.
3. "Training an eagle through sleep deprivation" (熬鹰): A traditional method of taming wild eagles by keeping them awake for extended periods until they submit to their trainer. Used metaphorically here to describe Lu Jiayi's intense work style that exhausts those around her.

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Liang Shi drove while Xu Qingzhu sat quietly in the passenger seat. The car was too quiet, but Xu Qingzhu still forced herself to stay alert, asking Liang Shi about her life on set in a desultory manner.

Who she had met, what scenes she had filmed.

Liang Shi answered each question, but these were all unfamiliar territories for Xu Qingzhu. She listened with little interest, even drowsily, yet she still forced herself to stay awake and listen, being the most supportive audience for Liang Shi's uninteresting life.

Just listening to her voice made Liang Shi feel exhausted.

Finally, she couldn't hold back anymore and said softly: "Baby, if you're tired, just sleep."

Her voice trailed off with a hint of choking.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the car window and looked at Liang Shi seriously from the side: "I'm not tired."

Yet her eyes were clearly reddened, her upper and lower eyelids fighting to stay open.

"Be good." Liang Shi's voice grew even softer. "I'll wake you when we arrive."

"I'm really not tired." Xu Qingzhu propped up her head with one hand, fingers threading through her hair. "You rarely come back. I want to look at you more."

Xu Qingzhu said with a smile: "I haven't seen you for days. I missed you so much."

"You can look at me slowly after we get home." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu still didn't listen to her. Her head just swayed against the car window. She didn't fall asleep, but her eyelids drooped down, leaving only a sliver open.

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The moment the car stopped, Xu Qingzhu opened her eyes.

Before Liang Shi could sit in her seat and space out, Xu Qingzhu got up and stretched exaggeratedly. But because the space inside the car was cramped, her arm bumped against the car window, causing her to gasp in pain.

"Looks like I've really been working overtime too hard lately." Xu Qingzhu muttered to herself. "Once I'm done with this busy period, I definitely need to rest."

There was a sense of forced casualness to it.

Liang Shi looked at her, her eyes glistening.

Because Xu Qingzhu was pretending so earnestly and working so hard at it, Liang Shi couldn't bear to expose her.

"Let's go home." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu opened the car door. "Finally, I can go home."

She would never have said that before. Usually, she would just say: "Okay." Or "Let's go."

More and more words, a tone that kept rising higher.

All of it revealed her deliberateness.

Liang Shi categorized her deliberateness as: feigning ease.

If her acting skills were better, Liang Shi would have been drawn into the illusion she wove.

But her acting skills weren't good. Her clumsy performance made it easy to see through her exhaustion.

Even though she was already trying so hard.

But Liang Shi really knew her too well.

They clearly hadn't been together for that long, yet her every small movement, every expression, seemed to be engraved in Liang Shi's mind.

As long as she said one sentence, Liang Shi could almost imagine the next one in her head.

The two entered the elevator quietly. From the moment they got out of the car, Xu Qingzhu had been clinging to Liang Shi's arm, practically walking pressed against her.

All the way to the door, where Liang Shi unlocked it and went inside.

It wasn't until they were standing in the entryway that Xu Qingzhu suddenly remembered something and frantically turned off the living room light that had already been switched on.

"Wait a moment." Without even changing her shoes, Xu Qingzhu ran into the living room, grabbed a bundle of things from the sofa, and went back to the bedroom.

Actually, Liang Shi had seen it the moment they entered.

It was a blanket and pillow.

During the days she was away, Xu Qingzhu had been sleeping on the sofa.

Liang Shi stood in the entryway, at a loss.

Suddenly, she didn't know what to say.

Her heart was filled with sourness, like biting into an unripe apricot in early spring—a mouthful of bitterness.

Liang Shi stood in the entryway like a puppet, not turning on the lights again.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu, having hurriedly thrown the blanket and pillow back into the bedroom, suddenly realized something as she walked out. She stood there, eyes meeting Liang Shi's in the darkness.

Liang Shi had taken off her coat and could hang it accurately on the coat hook even in the dark.

Underneath was a lotus-pink sweater paired with black skinny pants, making her legs look slender and long.

Liang Shi didn't say anything, just bent down to change into slippers.

From not far away, she could precisely sense Xu Qingzhu's embarrassment and helplessness.

Xu Qingzhu stood there, her ten fingers interlaced.

"Um..." Xu Qingzhu spoke into the silence, then stopped.

As if she didn't know how to explain.

Liang Shi smiled slightly. "Sleeping on the sofa—aren't you afraid of catching a cold?"

By tacit understanding, neither of them turned on the room lights, moving forward in the dark.

Xu Qingzhu said: "It's okay, just... there's been a lot of work lately, so I kept working on the sofa, and when I got tired, I'd just fall asleep."

She finally thought of an excuse. "I did catch a slight cold after sleeping there one night, so I brought the blanket out. Actually, I only slept there for two days..."

Her voice grew weaker as she spoke, because Liang Shi had already walked up to her.

Moonlight passed through the glass, casting a room full of silver radiance.

Xu Qingzhu raised her head to meet Liang Shi's gaze. Those light brown pupils were beautiful, yet seemed somewhat cold and distant.

As if nothing could be taken to heart by her.

Even though her own reflection was mirrored in those pupils.

Xu Qingzhu licked her lips. She slowly raised her hand to touch Liang Shi's jawline, calling her name earnestly and intently: "Liang Shi."

"I'm here." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes briefly. Glistening tears hung on her eyelashes. "I don't want to lie to you."

Liang Shi responded softly: "I know."

"I missed you so much." Xu Qingzhu said.

"I know." Liang Shi said: "Me too..."

Before Liang Shi could finish her words, Xu Qingzhu tiptoed up and kissed her.

Her coat was thrown on the ground. Both arms wrapped tightly around Liang Shi's neck, her whole body hanging on Liang Shi.

It had the desolate feeling of a road movie reaching its end—the last rays of sunset shining on a cliff's edge.

Chapter 156-3

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Xu Qingzhu was awakened by a nightmare again.

When she woke up, it should have been around 3:30 in the morning.

She had already woken up at this time for several nights now, then endured the long night alone.

Today seemed a bit better, because there was someone sleeping beside her. She carefully picked up her phone from the nightstand and found it was 4:00 AM.

Half an hour more sleep than before.

Perhaps because they had been more intense last night.

Liang Shi beside her was still sound asleep. Xu Qingzhu felt a dragging pain in her lower abdomen, the kind that pulled her whole body downward.

So she tiptoed to the bathroom.

It seemed her period had come early. There were bloodstains on her underwear.

She changed into fresh underwear and put on a new sanitary pad.

The pads in the cabinet should have been the ones left over from when Liang Shi last used them. There were only two left.

But there were quite a few panty liners.

The light in the bathroom was dim. She hadn't brought her phone, so she just sat on the toilet in a daze.

She raised her hand to wipe her forehead. The cold sweat from the nightmare had already evaporated. Her hand then rested on her forehead, supporting the weight of her upper body.

The pain in her lower abdomen was far less unbearable than the muddled feeling in her head.

It was like countless little people arguing in her mind. She couldn't hear what they were arguing about, but she could hear the chaotic noise.

To be more specific, it was like sleeping next to the Yujiang Bridge, with vehicles constantly passing over it, always able to hear the sound of tires rubbing against the ground.

Helpless. Powerless.

This had been Xu Qingzhu's frequent state lately.

Many times she simply didn't want to sleep anymore and would get up to work.

But there would always come a time when work was done, so she had bought a silent piano and placed it in Liang Shi's bedroom. When she couldn't sleep at night, she would try playing it—a way to pass the time.

But more often, she would sit blankly on the sofa all night until dawn.

She used to have a very regular schedule. In an era when young people were all trying to maintain nocturnal sleep schedules,¹ she was often teased by Sally and Lin Luoxi for not living like a young person at all.

She hadn't seen the 6 AM sun in many years; lately, she saw it every day.

Even sleeping had become something terrifying.

As soon as she thought about sleeping, she would start to resist.

She thought it was the bed's problem, so she moved the blanket and pillow to the sofa. Before sleeping, she would leave the TV on, find a relaxing slow-paced variety show or an old movie to watch, then continue sleeping.

But unexpectedly, there was still no improvement.

It was just easier to space out on the sofa.

So she lay on the sofa.

The most direct impact of poor sleep was mental fatigue. She looked completely drained of energy.

She was spacing out more and more during the day. Lin Luoxi even suspected she had been followed by some kind of monster, frequently being paranoid, and even suggested she find a shaman to take a look.²

Xu Qingzhu actually went. The fact proved that feudal superstition was not advisable.

That person wanted Xu Qingzhu to drink limewater, saying she was being followed by a fox spirit.

Lin Luoxi was dumbfounded at the time. Xu Qingzhu poured the limewater on the ground and drove back to the city to buy a hot milk tea.

These days had indeed been terrible.

But as long as she thought of Liang Shi, Xu Qingzhu felt it was okay.

She also knew she couldn't let Liang Shi know about these things. Based on Liang Shi's personality, if she knew, she would definitely feel guilty and blame herself.

So she had to act extra lively and push all her discomfort onto work.

Using work as a catch-all excuse could help Liang Shi avoid guilt.

Liang Shi probably knew something. This matter might also be related to Lu Jiayi.

But Liang Shi was unwilling to say or couldn't say, so Xu Qingzhu didn't ask.

Even if she asked, she wouldn't get an answer.

Either she would be deceived, or she would see Liang Shi in a difficult position.

She didn't want either, so she chose to suppress these things. After all, it wasn't a matter of life and death.

If Liang Shi hadn't appeared downstairs today, Xu Qingzhu would have already driven to the hospital to get sleeping pills. She had asked Zhao Xuning to prescribe some sleep aids.

But when she saw Liang Shi coming, she told Zhao Xuning she wouldn't go for now—she'd go tomorrow.

She thought it would be like last time, that she would be fine once Liang Shi came back, but she had only improved a little bit.

Xu Qingzhu sat in the bathroom sighing, rubbing her temples.

Only when the pain in her lower abdomen eased a bit did she get up.

She tiptoed back to the room again. Liang Shi wasn't sleeping soundly either and was awakened by the sound of the door. She was about to get up but was pressed back down by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi reached out to turn on the bedside lamp, her voice hoarse: "Did you have another nightmare?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu got into bed, her body curling up in Liang Shi's embrace.

She had just washed her hands, which were even colder than before. When she placed her hands on Liang Shi's waist, Liang Shi was mostly awakened.

"My period came." Xu Qingzhu said. "My stomach hurts a little, so I went to the bathroom."

Liang Shi's hand fell on her lower abdomen and rubbed it gently. "I remember it wasn't at this time last month."

"Right, last month it was around the same time as yours." Xu Qingzhu said. "Maybe it's because of work stress lately. It came early."

"Alright." Liang Shi asked. "Do you want a hot water bottle?"

"No need." Xu Qingzhu moved closer to her. "Just warm me up."

In the later part of the night, the heating wasn't as warm. Stepping barefoot on the floor was actually quite cold.

Xu Qingzhu didn't want Liang Shi to get up either, so she placed her somewhat cold feet on Liang Shi's calves. "Mm."

Liang Shi asked what was wrong, and she nuzzled into Liang Shi's embrace: "Your arms are so warm."

Liang Shi laughed softly: "Your constitution is really weak. When I finish filming this drama..."

She suddenly stopped mid-sentence.

"What?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together and said slowly: "I'll take you to the hospital to get checked out, or find a traditional Chinese medicine practitioner to help regulate your body."

Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "These are really just old problems. The Chinese medicine doctor said there's nothing wrong with me."

Liang Shi: "I don't believe it unless she tells me in person."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Footnotes:

1. "Nocturnal sleep schedules" (陰間作息): Literally "underworld schedule," this is Chinese internet slang for staying up extremely late and sleeping during the day, as if one's schedule belongs to ghosts or the dead rather than living people.
2. "Shaman" (跳大神的): Refers to folk practitioners who perform rituals involving trance-like states, often dancing or chanting, to communicate with spirits and cure ailments. This practice, while still found in some rural areas, is generally considered superstition in modern China.

Chapter 156-4

The wind had picked up outside. The bitter winter wind howled against the window frames, mixed with the sparse sounds of traffic, making the room seem exceptionally quiet.

Both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu spoke in low voices.

They chatted in a desultory manner, just like a couple who had been together for many years.

In such a tranquil atmosphere, Xu Qingzhu slowly closed her eyes and fell asleep again.

Perhaps because her body was in too much pain.

Xu Qingzhu slept exceptionally well this time. When she woke up, she found it had snowed outside. Fine snowflakes drifted down from above, the ground a vast expanse of white, and the whole world seemed to be tinted with brightness.

But the room was already empty. She reached out to feel the other side—the spot where Liang Shi had lain was already cold.

Xu Qingzhu's mood suddenly fell.

She raised her hand to pat her own cheeks, reminding herself that this was nothing, that she shouldn't be affected by dreams.

Dreams were only so terrifying because they were just dreams.

Liang Shi wouldn't do that.

Xu Qingzhu sat on the bed in a daze. Only after a long while did she reluctantly get out of bed, then got up and pulled open all the curtains.

The pure white scenery of the world unfolded completely, like a magnificent and brilliant painting scroll.

Even with just one color of white, it was dazzling.

Xu Qingzhu unconsciously crossed her arms, rubbing them. She inexplicably felt a bit cold.

She sniffled, then went to sit on the bay window. Just as she was about to grab a plushie from the side to hold, the door creaked and a head peeked out.

Ling Dang, with her twin braids, suddenly appeared. "Auntie, you're awake!"

Xu Qingzhu was pleasantly surprised. "Ling Dang."

Ling Dang nodded: "Yes, good morning, Auntie."

Then she shouted loudly toward the kitchen: "Gugu, Auntie is awake!"

Xu Qingzhu's eyes suddenly lit up. "Your Gugu is home?"

"Yes!" Ling Dang ran in, some ends of her hair sticking up and still damp. "Gugu is making congee for you. She's such a meanie—I wanted just a sip and she wouldn't let me. She said only you can drink it."

Xu Qingzhu pulled her into her arms and stroked her hair. "When did you get here?"

"Not long ago." Ling Dang said: "My mom's friend invited her to go shopping, so I came over to play with Gugu."

"Why is your hair wet?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Ling Dang shook her braids, and they ended up hitting Xu Qingzhu's face.

Both of them froze at the same time. Ling Dang immediately reached out to rub Xu Qingzhu's face, but because she had just come in from outside, her hands were terribly cold, making Xu Qingzhu shiver.

"Sorry." Ling Dang apologized pitifully.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "It's okay."

Then Ling Dang began talking non-stop about the interesting things at kindergarten. This included the last time it snowed, when Rainbow fell on her bottom in front of all the kindergarten kids. Her little down jacket was covered in snow, and everyone laughed at Rainbow.

Ling Dang quickly ran over to help her up, and Sheng Yu scolded everyone in front of all the kindergarten kids, saying those who laughed at Rainbow were bad kids.

And the time before that, Sheng Yu went to the bathroom but the lock was broken. It was Rainbow who noticed she was missing and went to the bathroom to rescue her.

And the time before that, Ling Dang had a fight with Shen Yiran and left her class's group during lunch, carrying her tray directly to Rainbow's class's table to eat. Sheng Yu expressed her disdain, but Rainbow spoke up for her when the teacher came to scold Ling Dang.

Also, Teacher Qi Jiao hadn't come to work in a long time.

Sheng Yu had mentioned it in front of them several times.

These were all trivial things from daily life that Ling Dang found interesting, and she shared all of them with Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu listened quietly.

Ling Dang talked until her mouth was dry. Just when she was about to run out of things to say, Liang Shi knocked on the bedroom door. "You two, get up and eat."

Ling Dang dashed out of the room to the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "How come you didn't leave?"

"It's snowing today." Liang Shi said: "I don't have any scenes. They were all moved to tomorrow. I saw you were sleeping soundly, so I didn't wake you."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu said: "I really did sleep well today."

When she woke up, it was almost 10:30.

She wasn't sure if this counted as breakfast or lunch.

But it didn't matter. She had no meetings today, so going to the company late was fine.

"I already told Lin Luoxi for you. Don't go to the company this morning." Liang Shi said: "Rest well and go in the afternoon."

Xu Qingzhu nodded in agreement.

At the dining table, only Xu Qingzhu had a bowl of congee in front of her. It was white fungus, goji berry, and lotus seed congee, smelling fragrant and sweet.

Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi sat down across from her. "Didn't you say your stomach hurts? Drink this and then go lie down in bed. Rest well."

Xu Qingzhu scooped up a spoonful, blew on it gently, and drank it under Ling Dang's expectant and envious gaze.

"Did you use rock sugar?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded: "Yellow rock sugar."

"We didn't have any at home." Xu Qingzhu said: "Did you go to the supermarket?"

"Mm, I stocked up all the groceries in the fridge." Liang Shi said: "You need to eat properly even when you're alone."

Xu Qingzhu: "Willing but unable."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I'll supervise you." Liang Shi said righteously.

Xu Qingzhu pouted, scooped up a spoonful, blew on it until it wasn't too hot, and fed it to Ling Dang.

Ling Dang's eyes lit up. "So sweet."

"You drink yours." Liang Shi said: "I made her a separate soup."

"I don't like seaweed soup." Ling Dang said aggrievedly. "I like sweet things."

Liang Shi flicked her forehead: "Little kids aren't allowed to be picky eaters."

Because Ling Dang was an unexpected guest at the house, there hadn't been time to make her another bowl of congee. She could only share the soup with Liang Shi.

However, this quiet home had gained a bit more warmth because of the unexpected guest's arrival.

Chapter 156-5

After finishing the congee, Xu Qingzhu didn't go back to sleep. Instead, she took Ling Dang to the other room to play the piano.

Ling Dang also had piano lessons, but she didn't really like them.

After all, practicing piano was quite a tiring thing. But she liked watching others play, so she sat on the bed and had Xu Qingzhu play for her.

Smooth and beautiful melodies drifted out from the room, and Ling Dang, being a qualified audience member, immediately applauded.

The whole home became much livelier.

Ling Dang was like a little sparrow, chirping and chattering all around the house.

Xu Qingzhu only sat there for a while before feeling a bit stuffy, and her lower back was a bit sore.

So she went back to the bedroom to lie down.

Strangely, though, she hadn't bled much during this period.

She guessed it might just be the early stage of her period.

Zhao Xuning even sent a message asking when she would come to pick up the medicine, or if Zhao Xuning should deliver it to her.

Xu Qingzhu felt embarrassed to have her deliver the medicine, so she told her to hold onto it for now and that she'd have her secretary pick it up in the afternoon.

Ling Dang left in the evening. Since Xu Qingzhu wasn't feeling well, she indulged herself and stayed home for the day. During this time, she even answered a video call from Lu Jiayi, who called to discuss details about their collaboration.

They talked for an hour on video alone.

At that time, Liang Shi was sitting beside Xu Qingzhu, watching a drama on an iPad with the volume turned very low.

Ling Dang had commandeered their TV to watch "Erta the Rabbit."¹

This dark fairy tale-style animated series was long and had many episodes, but Ling Dang watched it with great interest.

After Lu Jiayi finished discussing the collaboration with Xu Qingzhu, she also asked about her health.

Having learned that Xu Qingzhu hadn't gone to work, Xu Qingzhu answered each question politely.

Listening from the side, Liang Shi didn't feel much.

If yesterday, seeing Lu Jiayi and Xu Qingzhu walking out of the company together like a match made in heaven had made her jealous—

Then today, hearing the two chat about their collaboration with such perfect rapport, she no longer felt that jealousy. It was more of a sigh: so the system's driving force was this powerful.

Indeed, when it came down to it, Lu Jiayi was the one who belonged to the same world as Xu Qingzhu.

Their conversation wasn't entirely about work. At one point when discussing a certain topic, the two went off on a tangent.

Xu Qingzhu recommended a book to Lu Jiayi—a very long English title that Liang Shi had never even heard of. Lu Jiayi's eyes lit up and she agreed: "Yes, that's exactly what I wanted to say! I really like the perspectives in it too."

At the time, Liang Shi even looked it up on her phone. It was a very obscure book.

Yet such an obscure and difficult book had been read by both Lu Jiayi and Xu Qingzhu, and they shared the same views on it.

This was probably not just the power of the original plot, but more like meeting a soulmate whose soul was perfectly matched.

Liang Shi listened until they finished talking.

After hanging up, Xu Qingzhu opened her laptop and started working. When she worked, she was extremely focused, able to shut out the entire world.

Liang Shi watched her from the side for a while, then got up to cook.

Ling Dang followed her like a little tail, turning off the TV and going into the kitchen with her, leaving the living room space to Xu Qingzhu.

She couldn't really say whether she was sad or not. It was as if in that moment, Liang Shi had resigned herself to fate.

She seemed to have fought hard, but things hadn't gone as she'd hoped.

Lu Jiayi was the one who was more suited to Xu Qingzhu.

But Liang Shi didn't show it. She still thoughtfully cooked for Xu Qingzhu, then at night helped warm her stomach and held her while they slept.

When Xu Qingzhu was startled awake by nightmares, she gently wiped the sweat from Xu Qingzhu's forehead, then kissed her lips, softly stroked her back, and comforted her that such things wouldn't happen.

Xu Qingzhu buried herself in the crook of her neck, leaving deep marks.

After the nightmare, lingering tears of fear also fell on her skin.

Liang Shi accepted it all calmly.

Footnotes:

1. "Terra the Rabbit" (兔子不哭): Literally "Rabbit Don't Cry" - appears to be a fictional dark fairy tale-style animated series mentioned in the story.

Chapter 156-6

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The next day, the sun came out. The heavy snow melted, and the temperature dropped sharply.

Both of them took out their thickest padded jackets from the wardrobe. Afraid that Xu Qingzhu would catch a cold, Liang Shi even dug out the scarf she'd kept at the bottom of her trunk.

Liang Shi drove Xu Qingzhu to the company first, then drove to the set.

Gu Yixue didn't say anything. Apart from Sun Chengcheng, who had quite a few complaints about her absence, no one else had any reaction.

After all, she hadn't delayed the crew's work.

Even if Sun Chengcheng had complaints about her, she didn't dare make a scene.

At most, she would make a few passive-aggressive insinuations. Liang Shi just gave her a contemptuous glance, and she backed off.

After Sun Chengcheng backed off, Liang Shi sat there and started wondering: when did she change?

Before, when she heard Sun Chengcheng's passive-aggressive mockery, she would usually feel a bit embarrassed. Shame and self-blame would occupy most of her emotions.

She wouldn't have been like now—confident and bold, almost unrestrained.

It didn't start from when she died once.

At that time, she had just arrived in this world and was living cautiously, treading on thin ice. She wasn't like this.

When there were no scenes to film, she sat in the sunlight of the early-melting winter snow and began to recall carefully.

It seemed to have started from when Xu Qingzhu said she liked her.

Because she knew someone would like her unconditionally and would become her support, she slowly gained confidence.

It was Xu Qingzhu's love that propped up this confidence of hers.

Because Xu Qingzhu said: "Liang Shi, you're the best."

She said: "Liang Shi, I like you so much."

She would also say: "Teacher Liang, you really don't know how wonderful you are."

Liang Shi could feel her love at every moment, so she gained armor.

She was no longer the Liang Shi of the past who lived without edges. Even her gentleness had grown sharp.

Thinking of Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi smiled.

"What are you thinking about? Smiling so happily." Gu Yixue raised her hand to shade her eyes, then sat down beside her. She instinctively reached into her pocket to pull out a cigarette, but considering the person next to her didn't smoke, she stuffed it back in and played with a lighter in her hand instead.

Liang Shi said frankly: "Thinking about my wife, what else?"

Gu Yixue: "..."

Her matter-of-fact tone left Gu Yixue momentarily speechless.

Liang Shi asked Gu Yixue: "Are we almost done filming?"

"Almost." The lighter in Gu Yixue's hand flickered on and off. "I came to find you to discuss this. We'll push hard these next few days and finish within five days. Most of the remaining scenes are yours, so you'll have to work hard. You might have to pull several all-nighters. Can you do it?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes. But... why the rush?"

"Mm, I have something to do after filming." Gu Yixue said.

Liang Shi asked instinctively: "What is it?"

Gu Yixue paused, then smiled flirtatiously: "Guess?"

Her tone was light, but the expression on her face wasn't relaxed. It probably wasn't something that would make one feel at ease.

Liang Shi's ability to make connections wasn't weak either. She coughed softly and secretly leaned closer: "You're not planning to crash the wedding, are you?"

Gu Yixue's lips curved slightly. "Mm-hm."

Liang Shi: "..."

Although she knew this wasn't her place to interfere—she had heard before that in Haizhou City, the Gu and Shen families were the "two giants"—the marriage alliance between these two families really had nothing to do with a small fry like her.

But because she was fairly close to Gu Yixue, she couldn't help but say something more: "How are you going to crash it? When the time comes... it'll be very embarrassing."

From what she heard that day, Gu Yixue's status wasn't good. Although Liang Shi didn't mind her friends' moral boundaries, she felt Gu Yixue would be scorned for this.

Being an illegitimate daughter and wanting to steal her sister's arranged marriage partner—that already sounded fantastical enough.

Anyone who saw it would curse it as wishful thinking.

And it looked like Gu Yixue wouldn't succeed.

Because Shen Fenghe wasn't the type to give up her career for romance. In some ways, she was a bit like Lu Jiayi.

And that Gu Chunmian was obviously timid and cowardly.

She would bet that Gu Chunmian would one hundred percent compromise for the inheritance rights and attend the wedding.

So when the time came, they would all be paired up, and only Gu Yixue would be left alone. How embarrassing would that be?

But hearing this, Gu Yixue just laughed lightly. "Embarrassment doesn't matter."

She had always done things her own way, fearless of gossip.

Liang Shi stared at her. After a moment, all she could say was: "I wish you success."

"What if I don't succeed?" Gu Yixue asked in return.

Liang Shi paused. "Then I wish you would stop loving her."

Someone like Shen Fenghe would be very difficult for Gu Yixue to grasp.

Liang Shi shared her theory with Gu Yixue. Gu Yixue laughed so hard she clutched her stomach, laughing until tears fell. She looked at Liang Shi and patted her shoulder: "Little sister, how strong is your filter for me?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"But you are emotional." Liang Shi said: "Someone who can consistently create that kind of work isn't a match for that kind of career-focused person."

Gu Yixue fell silent.

After a long while, Gu Yixue looked at her: "Have you experienced this before?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi awkwardly turned her face away. "No."

Gu Yixue still couldn't hold back and lit a cigarette. Her face was shrouded in blue-gray smoke.

"I don't know either." Gu Yixue said in a low voice. "But I have to try."

If she didn't try, she would become someone else's forever.

Since becoming an adult, Gu Yixue had always been walking a tightrope.

Because her mother had been constantly criticized for interfering in someone else's marriage, and having grown up as the Gu family's illegitimate daughter, Gu Yixue's only bottom line in life was—don't destroy anyone else's marriage.

She didn't know how far she could go for Shen Fenghe.

But at least for now, she felt she still had to keep that last shred of principle.

She wouldn't interfere in a marriage, because that was a contract they had signed. No matter how unhappy that marriage was, no matter how terrible Shen Fenghe's partner was.

But during the dating stage, it was every woman for herself.

Perhaps a long time later, Gu Yixue would give up her principles for Shen Fenghe.

She thought that someone like her—a wandering ghost—was probably never meant to have something like principles.

Gu Yixue was lost in thought.

Liang Shi's voice was very soft. "Some walls you just have to hit yourself. When the time comes, call me, and I'll come pick you up."

This was a unique way of comfort between friends.

Hearing this, Gu Yixue laughed softly. "Thanks."

Chapter 156-7

//

Liang Shi would video call Xu Qingzhu every day, but because the scenes had recently been compressed and filmed together, the time she could call was extremely limited.

But Xu Qingzhu was visibly losing weight.

Every time, Liang Shi would tell her to eat more. She even ordered delivery from good restaurants near their home for her at night, but she still couldn't gain weight.

Even her mental state looked dazed.

That feeling of helplessness was becoming increasingly tormenting.

The closer they got to finishing, the more excited Gu Yixue became.

Perhaps because she had something to look forward to.

Liang Shi even saw the wedding dress Gu Yixue had ordered—beautiful yet unique, very suited to Gu Yixue.

If Gu Yixue were the bride that day, she would definitely be a bride that would make anyone who saw her gasp in admiration.

But Liang Shi was always worried she would return in defeat.

So she kept giving her warnings in advance, again and again. But one night, she and Gu Yixue drank too much.

Gu Yixue laughed with reddened eyes: "You think I don't know? Shen Fenghe loves her family too much. She loves her parents and siblings more than anyone. To her, it doesn't matter who she marries."

Gu Yixue said: "So why can't it be me?"

Liang Shi answered: "But she's engaged."

"Then I'll steal her away." Gu Yixue said: "Even if there's only a 1% chance, I still have to try. Otherwise, my life would be too boring."

"A life without Shen Fenghe—what kind of life is that?" Gu Yixue laughed lightly: "I have to try."

That day, because Gu Yixue cried, Liang Shi also cried along with her.

Her head buried in her knees, her whole body curled up.

As if she had finally realized her own helplessness.

Gu Yixue asked her: "What are you crying about?"

Liang Shi said: "My wife is going to die soon."

Gu Yixue: "...Are you sick? Why are you cursing your wife?"

Liang Shi closed her eyes. "If she stays with me any longer, she's going to die."

Gu Yixue paused: "What nonsense are you talking about?"

Liang Shi asked her: "If being with you would kill Shen Fenghe, or cause her great pain, would you still want to be with her?"

Hearing this, Gu Yixue sobered up halfway. She was silent for a very, very long time.

So long that Liang Shi had already started to doze off before Gu Yixue finally said: "Then I'd rather die."

Gu Yixue said: "I can die. Shen Fenghe can't."

Liang Shi's tears suddenly fell. She asked: "Why?"

Gu Yixue rubbed her head, suddenly taking on the air of a caring big sister. "Silly girl, how do you not know?"

"Shen Fenghe is my life." Gu Yixue said with the help of the alcohol: "If I die, she can still live. She can still have a better life."

"But if she dies, I won't live either." Gu Yixue propped up her chin, a desolate smile tugging at the corner of her lips: "My life would have no meaning anymore."

A life without meaning—what kind of life is that?

That night, Liang Shi cried until her eyes were swollen. She didn't even hear her phone ringing.

Chapter 156-8

//

On the night "Mo Xin Tu Mo" wrapped, Liang Shi drank quite a lot with everyone at the wrap party.

During the day, she had received flowers ordered by Xu Qingzhu, wishing her a happy wrap.

Even the two young girls Qi Tang and Tang Zui received some.

When it came to crew etiquette, Xu Qingzhu did it even better than Liang Shi.

Afraid of gossip, even Sun Chengcheng, whom Liang Shi disliked the most, received flowers sent by Xu Qingzhu—though clearly not on the same level as theirs.

Liang Shi drank until almost midnight, wavering between going home and not going home.

In the end, she got a designated driver to take her back.

The car stopped downstairs. She sat in the car, repeatedly slapping her own face to force herself to form a smile.

Only when she had recovered enough did Liang Shi go upstairs and home.

Xu Qingzhu had already woken up from sleep. The recurring nightmares of these past days had not stopped.

Because of insomnia and excessive dreaming, her memory had gotten increasingly worse. Her assistant had picked up the medicine for her and put it in her office drawer, but she would forget to bring it home every day.

So she hadn't had a good night's sleep for several consecutive days.

She had been lying on the sofa waiting for Liang Shi to come home, but no matter how long she waited, there was no sign of Liang Shi. She sent her a message asking when she would be back, but it went unanswered.

When she tried calling, she found the phone was off.

Probably drank too much at the wrap party and ran out of battery.

Xu Qingzhu was alone at home. It was so quiet she could hear a pin drop, which made her increasingly anxious and restless.

She simply took out a bottle of wine from the cabinet to stay awake. Today was Liang Shi's wrap party. If she came back, she should celebrate with her.

Even if Liang Shi didn't come back, drinking this bottle by herself should help her get a good night's sleep.

The rich aroma of wine spread through the room. Xu Qingzhu curled up on the sofa.

Normally, she would have the energy to read for a while, but lately she couldn't seem to do anything.

Even her emotions had become much more sensitive.

The other day, she saw a short video—just a few dozen seconds—and she actually cried.

And she cried uncontrollably.

Also, there was something wrong with her period. That day should have been when her period came, but there was only a little blood.

After that, there was nothing more.

Though the two days after that, she had rested fairly well.

It was just that two days later, the nightmare returned with a vengeance, and Xu Qingzhu had no way to deal with it.

She had even made an appointment with a psychiatrist, consulting the most professional psychiatric doctor. She also went to see her previous psychologist, Dr. Gu.

They all said more or less the same thing—her mental stress had been too great lately.

And indeed it was considerable.

The company needed new financing, needed to acquire smaller companies, needed to determine future development directions, needed to collaborate with the Lu family, and partner with Haiwei. Although her uncles were helping, she still had to handle the major matters herself.

For a very long time before this, she had just been a student.

It seemed she didn't have the ability to take over all these things.

Even in the collaboration with Lu Jiayi, Lu Jiayi had contributed more, basically helping her with the most complicated parts.

Xu Qingzhu really appreciated such a partner, but for some reason, in her interactions with Lu Jiayi, she always felt like she should like Lu Jiayi.

She was very puzzled by this feeling of hers.

After all, she had never felt this way before.

Later, she remembered that Liang Shi had once said she should have someone she liked more.

That person should be Lu Jiayi.

Things that should have been sharp and clear in her life now always took a long time to process.

Sometimes she couldn't even react at all.

Because of insomnia, Xu Qingzhu also felt her body becoming increasingly heavy.

That day after lunch, because the elevator was crowded, she tried taking the stairs. After climbing just two floors, she was panting for breath and ended up taking the elevator anyway.

Xu Qingzhu felt her life was dim and colorless, different from before.

However, she had now developed a habit—she would write in her diary every night.

The diary was monotonous and boring, with only two frequently repeated sentences:

[Remember to tell Liang Shi I love you today.

Silly sister, I love you so much.]

Xu Qingzhu didn't wait for Liang Shi, so she greedily took a sip first. Finding the taste good, she took sip after sip, until she finished a whole glass.

The moment the front door moved, she immediately got up and practically sprinted to the entryway.

She ran right into Liang Shi's arms as she came in.

Liang Shi hadn't expected it, but she instinctively caught her in an embrace. Afraid she would bump her head, she cushioned her forehead with her hand, preventing her from hitting her shoulder.

Xu Qingzhu greedily inhaled the scent on her body, but all she could smell was the lingering smell of alcohol.

She frowned and said: "How much did you drink?"

Liang Shi laughed softly and flicked her nose. "Wrap party. Drank a bit too much."

"Can you still drink with me?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "I've already opened the wine."

"Yes." Liang Shi said. "My alcohol tolerance is really good now."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She held Liang Shi's hand and led her into the house. The two sat side by side on the sofa.

Neither spoke, skipping all the pleasantries.

They simply drank, though Xu Qingzhu was nestled in Liang Shi's arms as she drank.

She sat on Liang Shi's lap, occasionally turning back to kiss her. Wine stains lingered on her lips.

Chapter 156-9

The living room lights were dim and warm. Below, the streets were bustling with traffic. The lights of the entire city complemented the lights in the living room, creating a wonderful atmosphere.

Then Xu Qingzhu, sitting on Liang Shi's lap, received a long and passionate kiss.

Xu Qingzhu was kissed until tears brimmed in her eyes.

Liang Shi smiled and wiped away her tears. "Crybaby."

Xu Qingzhu pouted and whispered in her ear: "Your kissing skills have improved."

Liang Shi's ear tickled, instantly feeling like it was on fire.

Almost most of the bottle of wine had been drunk by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi only indulged her mischief, sometimes even playing along.

Xu Qingzhu even "accidentally" spilled wine on her collarbone, then drank it clean, claiming she couldn't let it go to waste.

Liang Shi's body was casually draped over the sofa. Afraid of hurting her, she could only tilt her neck up.

She had bought a necklace earlier to match her outfit nicely, but in the end, she took it off and tossed it on the coffee table.

Xu Qingzhu also asked her: "You're not filming tomorrow, right?"

Liang Shi nodded.

Xu Qingzhu then bit a mark onto her collarbone.

Her teeth were sharp. The bite made Liang Shi gasp, and her hands could only grip the sofa, not daring to move her.

This counted as Xu Qingzhu bullying her.

Liang Shi was helpless. She went to pinch her waist, but found it empty beneath the pajamas—her waist was a size smaller than before.

For a moment, she didn't know what to feel.

Suddenly, she couldn't bear to pinch anymore. She just rubbed that small patch of skin at her waist, rubbing it red.

Xu Qingzhu even swatted her hand. "What are you doing?"

Liang Shi said: "You're bullying me."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes rolled mischievously, and she challenged: "Then come bully me too."

Liang Shi said helplessly: "You're just taking advantage of the fact that I can't bear to."

"Well, I can't bear to bully you either." Xu Qingzhu leaned close to her ear: "Jiejie~" ^1^

Her tone was seductive and drawn out, making one's heart tremble.

Xu Qingzhu's warm breath was entirely released into her ear, making it incredibly ticklish.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Bullying in bed isn't called bullying."

Liang Shi's face was like the red clouds at sunset, instantly spreading across the sky.

She raised her hand and gave Xu Qingzhu's bottom a light smack. "Have some decency."

"Who did you learn all this from?" Liang Shi asked through gritted teeth.

Xu Qingzhu was a bit drunk. She lazily draped herself over Liang Shi's shoulder, enunciating each word: "Self. Taught."

Xu Qingzhu said: "Because I love you so much, I want to give you the best of everything."

Xu Qingzhu wrapped her arms around her neck and stared at her. The corners of her eyes were reddened, like a pitiful little rabbit.

"Since you won't take the initiative, I learned it all." Xu Qingzhu said: "You just need to follow my pace. I'll teach you..."

Drunk Xu Qingzhu was shameless, but she also knew some things shouldn't be said too loudly. So she leaned close to Liang Shi's ear and said in almost a whisper: "How to devour me completely."

Liang Shi's hand slipped, and she nearly dropped her.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu was holding on tight.

This reaction made Xu Qingzhu giggle, burying herself in her embrace and laughing non-stop.

Liang Shi was helpless. She raised her hand and lightly patted Xu Qingzhu's back. "Stop learning those improper things. I'll learn on my own."

"Learn from whom?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "..."

"Matters of the bed." Xu Qingzhu nuzzled against her like a cat. "Naturally, it's better to learn from me."

Liang Shi: "..."

No more drinking in the future!

Really!

Footnotes:

1. "Jiejie" (姐姐): Means "older sister" in Chinese. Here it's used as a flirtatious term of endearment, with Xu Qingzhu using a drawn-out, coquettish tone.

Chapter 156-10

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Liang Shi was teased until she didn't know what to do, yet she only wanted to chat with her, not to fool around or do anything outrageous.

Fortunately, after finishing the wine, Xu Qingzhu started getting sleepy. She fussed for Liang Shi to carry her back to the bedroom, then wanted to nestle in Liang Shi's arms to sleep.

After Xu Qingzhu fell asleep, Liang Shi got up to make some honey water. She drank a glass herself first, then placed another glass on the nightstand, afraid Xu Qingzhu would have a headache when she woke up with a hangover.

After doing all this, she went to quickly wash up, then tiptoed to lie down beside Xu Qingzhu to sleep.

The room quieted down. Even the moonlight hid behind the clouds, leaving only a layer of haze.

Yet Xu Qingzhu had her brows tightly furrowed, a thin layer of sweat seeping from her forehead.

It was as if she had sunk into a deep sea. Everything before her eyes was blood-red, and someone kept dragging her down.

She clearly could float up. Her arms reached upward with all her might, but she still inevitably sank.

A moment later, the scene changed. She was thrown into a maze. The fog before her eyes was tinged with blood, as if it would bring out the most terrifying desires from the depths of one's heart.

Xu Qingzhu was frightened and wanted to escape, but someone grabbed her foot and dragged her back. Then came the sound of a knife slicing across skin.

Slash—

It sounded just like a knife tearing through expensive silk fabric.

But the pain was real. Her flesh seemed to split open in an instant.

Xu Qingzhu turned around in shock, only to see Liang Shi's face. She opened her mouth to call Liang Shi's name, but it was as if something had sealed her mouth—she couldn't make a sound at all.

She could only watch in terror as the other person walked toward her, then raised the knife in her hand. The sharp blade reflected a blinding light.

In just an instant, the knife plunged into her lower abdomen. The pain made tears stream down her face.

She wanted to say: "I'm Xu Qingzhu."

But she couldn't say anything. She could only watch as Liang Shi kept swinging the knife at her.

The pain of the knife piercing through skin and bone made her scalp tingle. If she had died and lost consciousness, that would have been fine, but she hadn't.

It was like facing her own death head-on, feeling the pain before dying.

No, that wasn't Liang Shi.

Liang Shi had said that if she had a knife in her hand, the blade would definitely be pointed at herself.

Xu Qingzhu kept hypnotizing herself, but... the one standing there was Liang Shi.

That knife pierced through her bones and flesh, dyeing all the fog blood-red.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't make a sound.

Then the scene changed. It was in the villa where they had lived before.

Xu Qingzhu's body wasn't injured, but the pain still lingered deep in her memory. She didn't dare move anywhere she had been stabbed.

Everything was pitch black.

Outside, the endless sound of cicadas could be heard, as if heralding the end of summer.

Xu Qingzhu curled up in a corner, not daring to make any sound. But suddenly her hair was grabbed, and that knife was pointed at her face again.

Then the knife slashed across her face, across her shoulder, across her lower abdomen... the blood spread.

Every cut was so painful.

Xu Qingzhu told herself this was a dream.

None of it was real.

She wanted to wake up from the dream, but she couldn't no matter what. There was even a voice whispering in her ear: "This is what's real... everything you see is fake."

Xu Qingzhu's whole body was in pain. She felt like the blood in her body was almost drained.

She opened her mouth but couldn't say a word.

She couldn't even match a dying cicada.

Xu Qingzhu lay on the ground, watching Liang Shi's face grow larger and larger before her eyes. She opened her mouth wide, wanting to say to her: "Wife..."

But she couldn't say it. She could only watch helplessly as that face kept growing larger, and larger, and then that sharp knife pierced through her heart.

Just like the dull pain she had felt countless times in nightmares.

"Mm!" Xu Qingzhu suddenly opened her eyes, staring at the ceiling.

Tears and sweat flowed down together.

It was another different scene.

But this time, she was lying beside herself.

Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi beside her. She was sound asleep.

The places that had just been stabbed by the knife were still throbbing with pain. She simply couldn't give the other person another chance. So she reached under the pillow and pulled out that fruit knife.

The sharp blade was pointed at Liang Shi's glands,¹ but tears fell uncontrollably onto Liang Shi's face.

At that moment, when Liang Shi opened her eyes, this was the scene she saw.

Xu Qingzhu sat beside her with disheveled hair, both hands gripping the knife, the blade pointed at her glands, her eyes completely red.

She seemed to be enduring tremendous pain.

Liang Shi called out to her in shock: "Wife."

Xu Qingzhu had a moment of confusion. The blade in her hand only lightly grazed the back of Liang Shi's neck.

Liang Shi called to her again: "Baby..."

Xu Qingzhu opened her mouth but still couldn't speak. Yet tears kept falling.

She suddenly pointed the blade at herself.

Just as she was about to plunge the blade into her own abdomen, Liang Shi reached out and grabbed her hand.

"Wife, give me the knife." Liang Shi didn't dare relax her grip, but still coaxed her in a soft voice.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her woodenly, her eyes blank.

She asked: "You're not going to kill me?"

Liang Shi was momentarily speechless. She shook her head with a bitter smile. "I love you. How could I kill you?"

"But don't you want to kill me?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"I won't." Liang Shi said gently, taking the knife from her hand at the same time.

There was blood on the tip of the knife—blood from the back of Liang Shi's neck.

But only a little.

Xu Qingzhu frowned, her expression pained. "Then who is the one trying to kill me?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, not knowing what to say. After a moment, she could only answer: "It's your dream. It's fake. No one is trying to kill you."

She took the knife from Xu Qingzhu's hand and threw it aside. It hit the floor with a clang.

In the darkness and silence, it was especially eerie.

Xu Qingzhu still looked at her in confusion: "Then who are you?"

"I'm Liang Shi." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lower lip, looked at her, and then said as if suddenly understanding: "You're the Liang Shi I love."

Liang Shi nodded, tears in her eyes: "Yes, the one you love."

"Then do you love me?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi's tears suddenly fell. "I do."

Xu Qingzhu threw herself into her arms and kissed her throat. "Jiejie, please don't cry, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu took her hand and placed it on her own heart. "It hurts so much here."

Liang Shi held her tight.

After a long time, Xu Qingzhu fell into a deep sleep in her arms.

Footnotes:

1. Glands (腺體): In the ABO universe of this novel, glands are special organs located at the back of the neck that produce pheromones. They are crucial for marking bonds between Alphas and Omegas. Damaging them can cause permanent harm, as mentioned in the novel's synopsis.

Chapter 156-11

What had just happened with Xu Qingzhu seemed like just a dream Liang Shi had.

But looking at the knife lying quietly on the floor, still reflecting light, Liang Shi knew—it wasn't a dream.

It was the impact of the world's operating laws falling on Xu Qingzhu during the correction process.

From the looks of it, both she and Lu Jiayi were fine.

So all the damage from changing this major event had been borne by Xu Qingzhu alone.

She didn't know how long Xu Qingzhu would have to endure this before the change from this major event could be balanced out.

So... it seemed... she could only follow the plotline.

Liang Shi was no longer sleepy at all.

After Xu Qingzhu fell asleep, Liang Shi lay there and kissed her forehead, then tiptoed out of bed.

On her phone was a divorce agreement that the lawyer had just drafted. She went to another room, got the printer, and printed out the document.

The clacking sound of the printer outputting paper was particularly jarring in the silent room.

Liang Shi read through each clause. She wasn't asking for anything—she chose to leave with nothing.

Even though she didn't have many assets, she still gave half to Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi kept clicking the ballpoint pen in her hand, clicking it over and over.

In the end, she still signed her name on the divorce agreement.

Moonlight refracted into the room, casting silver radiance across the floor.

That blade that had just touched her glands still had traces of her blood on it.

She put away the knife, then took out her suitcase from the wardrobe. She packed some things she needed. Then, when the distant horizon showed the first pale light of dawn, she tiptoed into the bedroom to look at Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu was still sound asleep, clearly no longer having nightmares.

Liang Shi kissed her cheek, then drew the curtains tight and closed the door.

She left, pulling her suitcase behind her.

This was a rare good dream for Xu Qingzhu in recent days.

She dreamed of holding a wedding with Liang Shi. The original wedding had been crude and hasty, and it had been with that person.

Xu Qingzhu had married her with expectations, more or less.

But later she discovered that person wasn't the one she wanted to marry.

However, last night she dreamed that she and Liang Shi had a wedding at a mountain villa, and she had thrown the bouquet to Lin Luoxi.

Because Lin Luoxi was pregnant.

It was a bit absurd, but it was a beautiful dream.

After waking up, Xu Qingzhu stretched lazily and saw that it was already 9:30 in the morning.

She had drunk too much again last night. Her memory seemed to stop at when she and Liang Shi were kissing on the sofa.

No matter how hard she tried to recall what happened after, she couldn't remember.

She reached out to feel the side of the bed—it was already cold.

As if no one had ever lain there.

Having gotten enough sleep, her mental state was better than usual. She lifted the covers and got out of bed, seeing the honey water on the nightstand. Although it had cooled down, she still picked it up and drank half of it.

Then she pulled open the curtains. Sunlight poured in, and she called out loudly: "Teacher Liang!"

But no one answered.

Xu Qingzhu walked out holding the cup, muttering to herself: "Did she go grocery shopping?"

Walking out of the bedroom, the house was empty.

Xu Qingzhu pouted. She looked around the kitchen and saw that there was congee already simmered, kept warm in the pot.

On the refrigerator was a sticky note: [Baby, make sure to eat properly!]

Xu Qingzhu peeled it off to look at it, then stuck it back on.

She didn't feel like eating yet, so she went to the bathroom to wash up. But when passing by another room, she noticed the door was open. She thought Liang Shi was secretly playing the piano, but when she pushed the door open, the room was also empty. Even the bedsheets didn't have a single wrinkle.

Xu Qingzhu felt rather disappointed.

But then she saw the A4 paper on the table—something that hadn't been in this room before.

There were only two people in the house. If she hadn't put it there, it must be Liang Shi's.

Curiosity drove her to walk over, and then she saw the five large characters at the top—
Divorce Agreement.

The document was three pages, already stapled together, very neatly arranged.

It was the kind of binding that even a perfectionist boss like Xu Qingzhu couldn't find fault with.

And there were two copies.

Both had Liang Shi's fingerprints pressed on them, with Liang Shi's name signed.

On the table was also a sticky note: [Let's get divorced. After you sign, put the other copy in the delivery box downstairs. I'll come get it. As for the reason... there's no reason. I'll have my phone turned off these days. You don't need to look for me. Oh, and don't cry. If you still want both of us to be okay, then sign.]

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

The cup in her hand suddenly fell to the ground, shattering on impact.

Ice-cold honey water spilled all over the floor.